

The 5-Minute Desk Reset Card

*The complete tool from **Calm in 5** by Simon Gebhart.*

This card works on its own. If you skipped straight here, you have everything you need to use it.

First, the one rule behind all of it: Breathe *less, slower, lighter* — not more and bigger. Get your rate down toward six breaths a minute. Don't gulp.

SITUATION 1 — Racing heart before a meeting, but you have a few minutes. Use: **Cyclic sighing, 5 minutes** (shorten to 1-2 minutes if that's all you've got).

- Double inhale through your nose: a normal nose inhale, then a second short sip on top to fill all the way.
 - Long, slow exhale through your mouth, like a quiet sigh, until empty.
 - Repeat continuously. No counting. Let it go slow.
 - Duration: aim for 5 minutes; even 1 minute helps.
 - Discreet: looks like normal breathing. Camera-off or in-the-room safe.
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SITUATION 2 — Spiraling thoughts, wired, over-breathing. Use: **Light slow nose breathing, ~3-5 minutes.**

- Mouth closed. Breathe in through the nose *smaller* than feels natural — about 70% of normal.
 - Slow, soft exhale through the nose.
 - Aim for roughly 6 breaths per minute: in for about 5 seconds, out for about 5 seconds.
 - You should feel a mild, tolerable air hunger. That faint “not quite enough air” is the CO2 normalizing — it means it's working. Don't push to discomfort.
 - Duration: 3-5 minutes.
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SITUATION 3 — Post-conflict shakiness or near-panic, breathing won't cut it, you need it NOW. Use: **Cold-face reset, 30 seconds to 2 minutes.**

- Cold on the forehead, around the eyes, upper cheeks: ice pack, cold gel mask, frozen item in a paper towel, or both hands of cold tap water.
 - Hold ~30 seconds up to 2 minutes. Cold, not painful.
 - Optional and only if safe for you: a short, comfortable breath hold while the cold is on — skip if you have any heart, blood-pressure, or breathing condition.
 - Then 3-4 slow nose breaths to settle.
 - Expect your body to settle (slower heart, blunted stress response) even if the *feeling* of calm lags. That's normal.
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If you're not sure which to pick: start with Situation 1 (cyclic sighing). If you're too activated to breathe slowly, do Situation 3 (cold) first to take the edge off, *then* breathe.

Here's how that plays out in a real workday. Your manager pings "got a sec?" with no context and your stomach drops — that's Situation 1; run a minute or two of cyclic sighing before you reply, while you're still reading the message. The 4 p.m. status call where you can feel the dread building all afternoon — that's Situation 2; a few minutes of light nose breathing in the half hour beforehand keeps you from walking in already wired. You just got off a tense call and your hands are shaking — that's Situation 3; cold to the face at the sink, then breathe. Same three tools, mapped to the moment, no decision required when you're activated.

Safety line: These are resets, not treatment. If you have a heart, lung, or blood-pressure condition, are pregnant, or have a panic or anxiety disorder, talk to your doctor before using breath holds, air-restriction, or cold deliberately.

That card is the whole machine. Print it, screenshot it to your phone, tape it inside a desk drawer. The value of a reset card is that it's already decided for you when you can't decide.

Notice what the card is *not* doing. It's not telling you to find a quiet room, lie on the floor, close your eyes, or download anything. Every protocol on it is desk-discreet, under five minutes, and eyes-open. That's deliberate — because "**I can't take a break to calm down, I'm at my desk**" is the exact constraint this whole book is built around. A calming technique you can't actually deploy at your desk, in the moment, is just trivia. These you can run while the meeting invite is still on your screen.

Do this now: Personalize it. Write down your three most common stress triggers — the specific situations, in your own words ("the 4pm status call," "after my manager pings me 'got a sec?'," "when the inbox count climbs"). Next to each, write which of the three protocols you'll use. Now your card isn't generic. It's pre-mapped to *your* week, ready before the spike hits.

More printable cards like this, free: [Simon Gebhart's Field Notes](#)

The full guide: amazon.com/dp/B0H5BQVFYM